

‘Arre Lala, you say one thing to our face and something else behind our back. Just because you were not smart enough to get a good price from us for Ambuja, you think we are **###%^ about who will go to the extent of selling our own mothers for an extra profit? Isn’t that what you are going around telling people about us?’ AS said, still smiling.

‘I think somebody is misinforming you. I don’t recollect having said anything like that,’ I said with a straight face.

It was now PS’s turn to needle me.

‘If you said that, be man enough to admit it. Even otherwise, it doesn’t matter what you think of us. There are too many amateurs like you who don’t know the first thing about trading and go around whining when they are beaten,’ he said, resting his palm on my shoulder. The tone in which he spoke suggested he would have loved to punch me in the face. I bristled, but tried hard to keep my wits about me.

After that incident, I kept away from them as far as possible. The few times we ran into each other in the ring, it was an effort for us to be mutually civil. PS would glower at me and AS would have a mocking grin ready for me.

But I could not live down the humiliating exchange I had had with them. And when I heard about the domination AS-PS enjoyed in the delivery auction market, I sensed an opportunity to get under their skin. To cut a long story short, I managed to befriend an official in that department using Rajesh’s network.

The offers for the auction were submitted in a sealed envelope to the concerned department of the stock exchange.

I went up to my boss and told him that I had figured out a way for our clients as well as the firm to make good money by tendering shares in the auction. Our clients had been regularly participating in the auction process, but with limited success. I did not tell my boss how I planned to swing things in our favour. All I told him was that it would cost money. He trusted me well now, and instructed the accountant to give me up to Rs 10,000 whenever I asked for it.

My contact in the department would tip me off about the offers. I was smart enough not to be greedy and draw attention to myself. I would select two or three stocks that offered us a good chance to make a neat profit, and would quote offers accordingly. Twice, I quoted 10 paise below offers put in by AS and twice I did that with PS’s offers too. On each of these